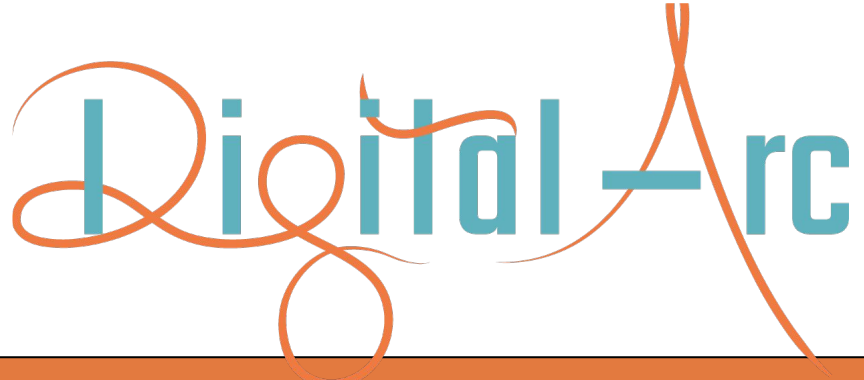


Becoming a Community through the Creation of Community Archives

Challenges and Opportunities of
Grant Funding the Preservation of
Black Midwestern History



Jazma Sutton (Moderator) | Kalani Craig | Michelle Dalmau | Bryan Glover | Jacqueline Johnson | Joslyn W Kelly | Samuel Love

IUB, Miami & UIUC

Kalani Craig, Michelle Dalmau, Vanessa Elias (UT San Antonio), Jazma Sutton

INTRODUCTION

DigitalArc today: A team of academics and community leaders working together to refine a community archive toolkit that includes

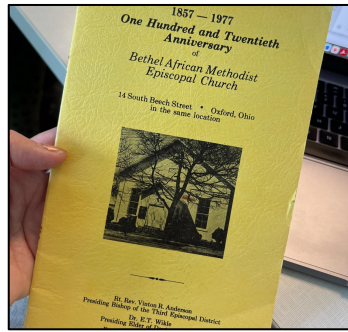
- event & collection planning
- oral-history & archiving guides
- digital-archive creation
- funding & development resources

The individual histories of each part of the team are longer and more complex.

The screenshot shows the DigitalArc website interface. At the top, there are navigation links for "OUR COMMUNITY" and "OUR COLLECTION". Below these, a header states "An exhibit platform for collective storytelling & community archives" and "A SAMPLE DIGITALARC COLLECTION SITE". The main content area includes a section titled "About this site" with text about archiving and community storytelling. A large orange box highlights the URL <https://digitalarcplatform.github.io/>. Below this, there are instructions on how to use the template, including links to create a GitHub account and a quick start guide. A button labeled "View the template" is visible. On the right side, there is a photo of a building and a contact email address: [digitalarcplatform \[at\] gmail.com](mailto:digitalarcplatform[at]gmail.com). The footer contains copyright information: "DigitalArc: An exhibit platform for collective storytelling & community archives. DigitalArc Community Archiving Template - Demo Site. DigitalArc: An exhibit platform for collective storytelling & community archives, 2024 - 2026. DigitalArc Jekyll Theme by Kalani Craig is licensed under..."

Digital Archiving Team & Partners

- Bethel AME, Oxford OH
- Voices of Gary, Gary IN
- Roberts Settlement, Hamilton IN
- Indiana University Bloomington
- Miami University
- University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign



The IU Back Story

Inspired by Dr. Wingo, Mr. Anderson &
Remembering Rondo

- 2018-19: History Harvest approach with student-centered focus
- 2019-20: IUB Centennial highlighting marginalized voices on IU campuses
- 2019-21: Longtown community ownership of material/intellectual culture with Dr. Sutton
- 2022-25: The beginnings of DigitalArc, and a partnership with La Casa IUB for its 50th anniversary

2020-21

Remembering Freedom: Longtown and Greenville History Harvest

Histories

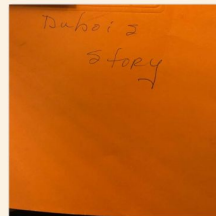
Remembering Freedom

Longtown and Greenville History Harvest

Longtown Descendants

"By memory, those fond associations and ties of love which unite us together on earth, will be preserved. Memory should be cultivated. Like all other faculties of the mind and body, its vigor and activity depend on its use. Memory is exercised the stronger it becomes." -J. B. Harrison, Greenville Settlement, 1864

Descendants' Historical Collections



Gladys Collins

View items from the collection of Gladys Collins



Longtown Descendant Facebook Group

View items from the collection of Longtown Descendant Facebook Group



Ricky Cottman

View items from the collection of Ricky Cottman

The v Green Longt

- Ricky C
- Julia B
- (née H
- Patricia
- Tera C
- Jim
- Celest
- Cleo F
- Woodr
- Roan

The Outcome: DigitalArc Values

Community Ownership and Control

Accessible, Scaffolded Support and Training

Equity in the Historical Record

Sustainable, Community-Led Capacity Building

Transparency Around Digital Ethics and Infrastructure

Investment in Intergenerational and Local Knowledge

<https://digitalarcplatform.github.io/values/>

Bethel AME Church - Becoming Community

Established 1857

Oxford, OH

A historic pillar of the community, serving as a center for worship and social action since the mid-19th century.



History of the African Methodist Episcopal Church

The First Independent Black Denomination

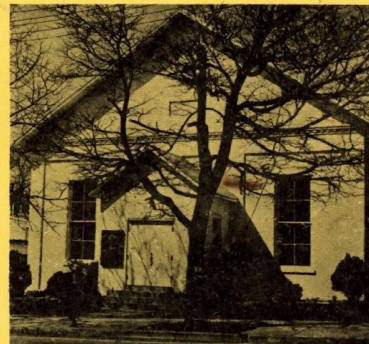
The African Methodist Episcopal (AME) Church holds a significant place in history as the first independent Black denomination in the United States.

Founding & Origin

It was organized by **Richard Allen**, a former slave, in Philadelphia, PA, in 1816.

Bethel African Methodist Episcopal Church

14 South Beech Street • Oxford, Ohio
in the same location



Founding of Bethel AME Church

A Local Landmark

The church is a celebrated landmark of Oxford, OH. In 1857, the building was purchased from Joel Collins.

Historical Significance

Bethel African Methodist Episcopal Church stands as the oldest African American congregation in Oxford, Ohio.



Formation of Worship

Humble Beginnings

Early meetings occurred in a log house built by Jeremiah Lewis and Thomas Rollins.

Circuit Connections

In the early days, Bethel was on a circuit with Payne AME Church in Hamilton, OH.



Legacy

The DigitalArc Toolkit

The DigitalArc Toolkit (DigitalArc) provides Bethel the opportunity to document its history, honor the church and the parishioners, and allows the Bethel congregation ownership of its history.

rd Allen

der,



Bishop Richard Allen



Sar

Contributions to the Community

Bethel AME Church has contributed to the community with:

- Tutoring programs for children in the Talawanda School District
- Partnership with local food pantries
- Support of residents by programs led Estella Hasty Women's Missionary Society.

Contributions to the Community

Bethel AME Church has contributed to the community with:

- Tutoring programs for children in the Talawanda School District
- Partnership with local food pantries
- Support of residents by programs led Estella Hasty Women's Missionary Society.

Notable Members of Bethel AME Church - Oxford

Hiram Revels

The first African American to serve in the United States Congress, Revels served as an early pastor of Bethel AME Church in 1870.



Dr. Mark Tyler

Dr. Mark Tyler, who served as the pastor of **Bethel AME Church - Oxford** from 2002-2004, was elected the **Executive Director**, Department of Research and Scholarship/Historiographer in 2024.



Bethel AME Church Oxford OH - History Harvest

Preserving Our Legacy

The History Harvest project captures the rich narrative of Bethel AME Church through the preservation of personal artifacts, community stories, and historic documents.



DigitalArc

Empowering History

The website digital collection will allow users to learn about our past and present history through the use of images, metadata and oral history.

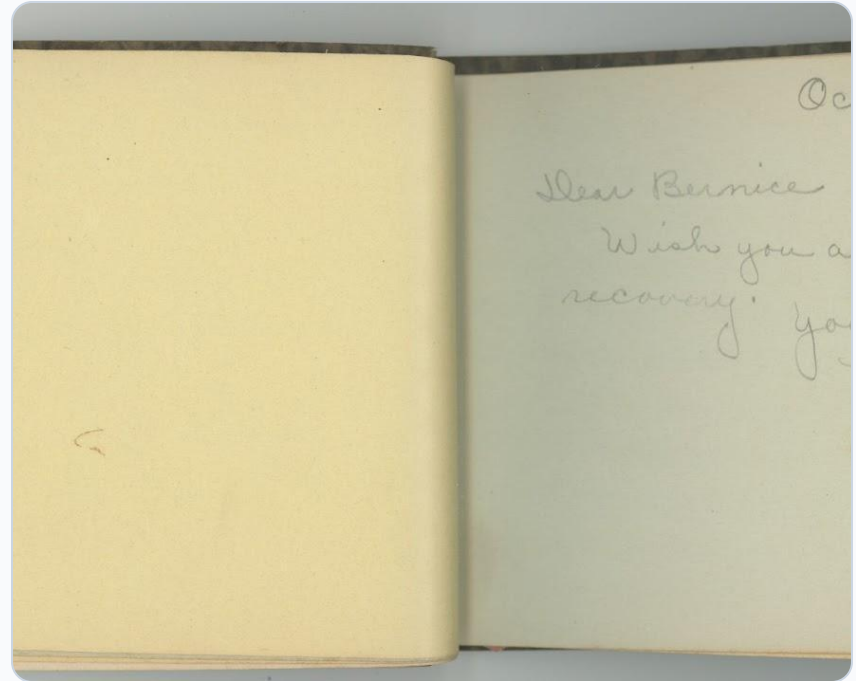


This community led archive is the vehicle for community members to conceive and lead the work of digital archives.

Bethel Congregation

Active Engagement

The members of Bethel have become engaged by looking in their scrapbooks, photo albums, contacting family members, and talking about their history.



Significance of Project

Narrating History

The DigitalArc Project allows Bethel to partner with scholars to narrate Bethel AME Church History in a way that adds significance to our history.



The project shares our history with the world. We thank the organizers.



ROBERTS SETTLEMENT

**Roberts Settlement is
home to one of the
earliest and most
enduring examples of
Indiana's Black pioneer
settlements founded by
free people of color**

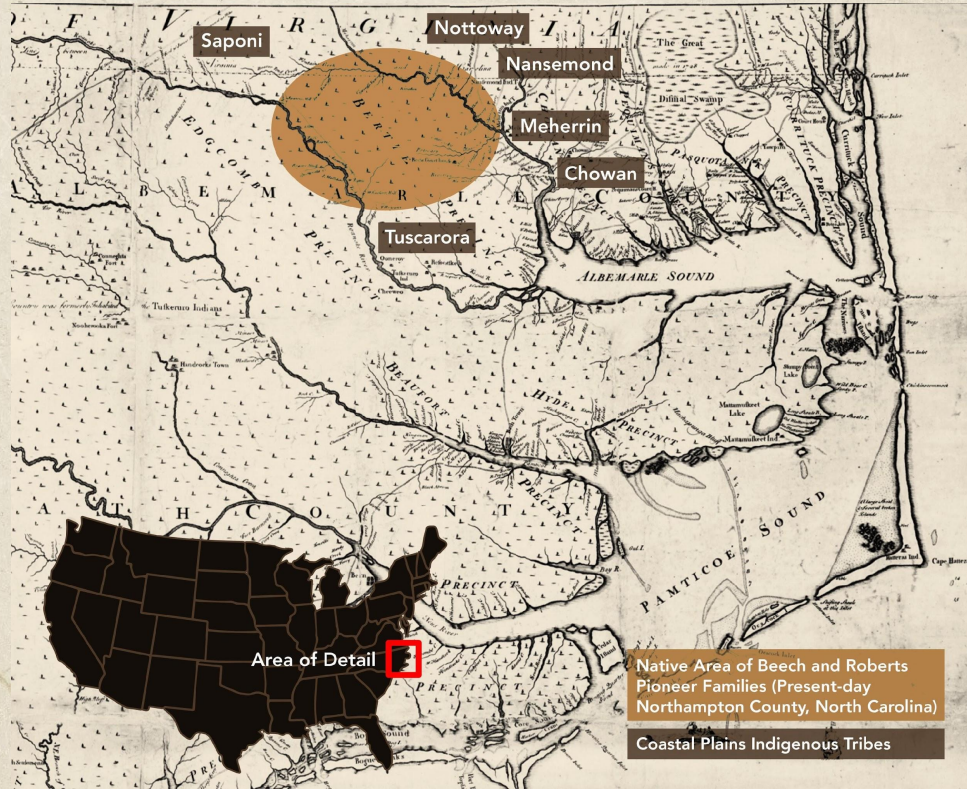


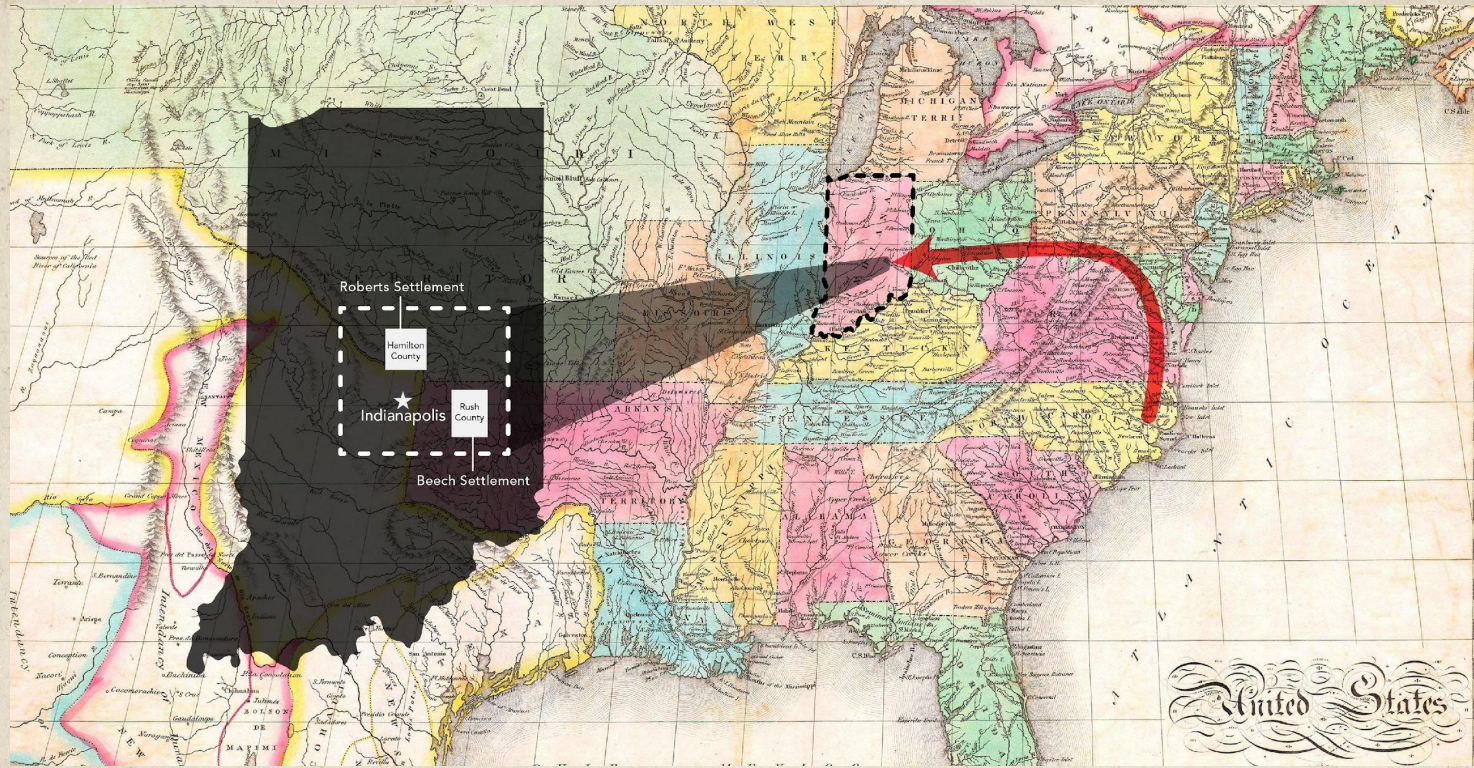
Ancestors of Roberts Settlement's founders had been free for generations – possibly as early as the mid-1600s



Source: Wolfe, Brendan. Colonial Virginia. (2020, December 07). In *Encyclopedia Virginia*. <https://encyclopediaivirginia.org/entries/colonial-virginia>

FPOC migrated from Virginia to the North Carolina Coastal Plains in the early 1700s





The earliest Roberts pioneers began migrating to the Ohio and Indiana frontier in the 1820s

African Proverb: Until the lion tells his/her story the story will always be about the lion hunter

Be the ones who tell our story

Strengthen, refine and polish our story – Build our reputations as THE experts

Identify where local history is being discussed...and be there!

Encourage and assist others who can also tell our story

Leverage relationships for opportunities to tell our story e.g., schools, service organizations, historical societies

...because few people know our story like we do!



The evolution of our Roberts Settlement storytelling

RS, A Mixed-Blood Agri.
Community – Edgar
Conkling, PhD
(Mid-1950s)

Interviews and direct observation
Records e.g., land deeds, free papers and family letters
Genealogy
Comparative sociological research

Southern Seed, Northern
Soil – Stephen Vincent,
PhD
(Mid- 1990s)

Sources & methods as above
E. Conkling's *Roberts Settlement, A Mixed Blood Community*
Microfilm resources e.g., newspapers, military service records, Cherokee registration applications
Paul Heinegg's genealogical research on FPOC

RS Family History &
Genealogy – Lezli Davis
(Ongoing)

S. Vincent's *Southern Seed, Northern Soil*
E. Conkling's *Roberts Settlement, A Mixed-Blood Community*
Ancestry.com and other public resources e.g., newspapers, federal census, birth/death certificates, military
Oral histories, family photo, letters and documents letters

Building our Roberts
Settlement story –
COLLABORATION!

Studying and utilizing the above materials
Identifying easy-to-understand themes that best convey our story
Finding grants and asking for community financial support
Choosing the individuals and their stories that resonate – **COLLABORATION** with descendants!
Integrating a powerful and flexible storytelling app with exhibit traditional exhibit storytelling techniques

How we connect our stories with public audiences



Overarching themes that frame our story



Evidentiary support



Confronts difficult history



Stories that illuminate and inspire

- **Stories that connect past and present**
- **Stories that humanize history**
- **Diversity of stories told**
- **Shared authority – descendant community may contribute**

The Legacy Walk at Roberts Settlement





ROBERTS

WALDEN

BROOKS

WINBURN

Legacy Walk at Roberts Settlement

We are pleased by our growth and progress; however, we can continue to expand and improve our story by...

- Connecting with “missing” descendants to reveal details on dormant branches of our family tree
- Continuing to do research on the entire set of families that were part of Roberts Settlement—our genealogy is the genealogy of a community
- Encouraging descendants to take down oral histories from their elders and youth—everyone is a potential storyteller
- Convincing descendants that family “treasures” tucked away in closets, attics and basements have value and may provide clues to new and old stories
- **Organizing artifacts, photos, letters, journals etc. in a Roberts Settlement community archive that excites, invites and activates more participation**

The DigitalArc platform is a missing tool in our toolkit, but will it be the answer to broader community participation?

What's Working

- **Professional, hands-on support building metadata, website, etc.**
- **Flexible “model” that communities can adapt to their needs**
- **Scalable platform**
- **Complements what we are doing with our website and storytelling app**

Concerns

- **Need more hands-on with GitHub platform**
- **Creating metadata that is useful to our community users and the institution that holds our collection**
- **Need more community involvement**
- **Don't have an internal succession plan**

Thank You!



VOICES OF GARY

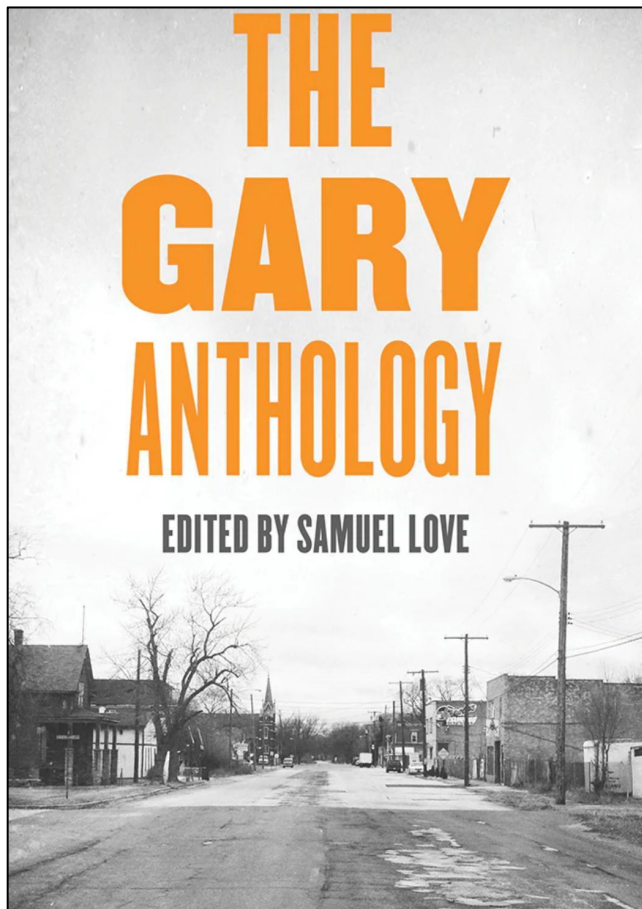
MIDWESTERN HISTORY ASSOCIATION
OXFORD, OHIO
APRIL 30, 2026

JOSLYN KELLY • SAMUEL LOVE

GREETINGS FROM



THE SOCIAL HISTORY OF GARY



جاري
GARY

GARY VOICES
MEMORY WALK

GARY VOICES

Bridging the Gap



CHALLENGES

HERE TODAY GONE TOMORROW



TECH COMPLEXITIES



THE DOUBLE EDGED SWORD



r/Indiana 7y ago
stray_girl



**Gary, Indiana most miserable city in the U.S.
according to Business Insider**

<https://www.wthr.com/article/gary-tops-list-most-miserable-cities-america-hammond-and-anderson-included?fbclid=IwAR1HAh6GU6oplhGSAIWPpSY3s8pu98uDrXaOxe4P9K1RC56BACEvdkaZygv>

👍 193 🗨 32

OUTSIDE PROJECTIONS

VOICES OF GARY

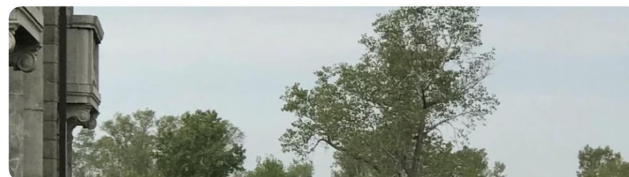
<https://voicesofgary.github.io>

J's BREAKFAST CLUB

2601 Broadway, Gary, IN



SAMUEL LOVE



Samuel Love

@SamuelLove

1.16K subscribers >

Documenting the cultural and ecological terrain of the Calumet Region.more

Grant-Funding Challenges

Michelle Dalmau

Logistics

Timelines Disconnect

Community-driven digital archiving work is often driven by community members who *volunteer* their time outside of their jobs, families and other commitments.

The grant project team needs to be gracious, providing space for community partners to meet their goals (and thereby the goals of the grant) while managing grant expectations.

State of the World Disconnect

Challenge to anchor to grant deliverables when they felt, in light of the state of the world, and everyday life challenges, insignificant.

Relationships

Community Ownership & Control

The project centers community autonomy over stories, artifacts, and archives. It ensures that communities, not institutions, decide what is shared, how, and with whom. Participants can set access levels, retain ownership, and use platforms that best fit their needs.

Degrees of Embeddedness

Roberts Settlement & Bethel AME: Jazma Sutton engaged in this work as part of her own personal and research interests.

Voices of Gary: The “conduit,” an archivist from IU Northwest, took another job. I (Michelle) became the sole contact, with geography in the way. I wholeheartedly support the stories core to Gary, Indiana’s legacy, but I am not part of that story.

Organizational Structures

Formal (Roberts Settlement)

- Board of directors that guide their community work with grassroots activation
- Intentionally collecting histories for decades
- Experience with partnering with cultural heritage organizations, historians, etc.
- Co-PI Sutton is embedded, solidifying communication

Semi-Formal (Bethel A.M.E.)

- Board of directors but also a grassroots movement to document the church's history & impact on the Oxford, OH community
- Eager to curate their histories, helps when led by a professional archivist (Jacky)
- Co-PI Sutton is embedded, solidifying communication

Informal (Voices of Gary)

- Self-created group made up of folks who engage in community work irrespective of this grant (collective)
- Each have demonstrated outputs in curating Gary's history and those experiences may have impacted expectations
- PI Dalmau is not embedded, communication was challenging at times

Technology & Sustainability

Preservation

- Importance of providing guidance on the preservation of physical artifacts
- Questions about long-term digital preservation of assets ... is that even possible or realistic?

Technology

- Post-processing and publishing parts of the toolkit are seen as different or intimidating or overwhelming (community didn't create the workflows, academics did)
- Scaffolding for partner support in these areas was built into the grant; but if there's an initial roadblock, all the support we offer does not matter

Sustainability

- Stewardship is a theme we still need to fully explore
- Every partner has different circumstances that impact ongoing support & scaffolding for the project: institutional v. grassroots approaches to this work.
- How does one shape governance to ensure sustainability? What is realistic to sustain over time?

Digital Arc

THANK YOU

Kalani Craig (UIUC)
Michelle Dalmau (IUB)
Bryan Glover (Roberts Settlement)
Jacqueline Johnson (Bethel AME, Oxford, OH)

Joslyn Kelly (Voices of Gary)
Samuel Love (Voices of Gary)
Jazma Sutton (Miami University)